HOW BIG TEMPLES GUARD THEIR DONATIONS



ALAMY

TIRUPATI, ANDHRA PRADESH

The Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) runs one of India's most elaborate donation-management systems. With hundi offerings of Rs 1,738 crore in 2025-26—about Rs 4.75 crore a day—the temple has to replace 12-18 cash receptacles daily. The sealed hundis are moved under tight security to the Parakamani counting centre, where CCTVs monitor their opening in the presence of senior officials and vigilance staff. Cash is counted by machine, monitored in real time and deposited alternately with SBI and Union Bank. Jewels are valued by appraisers, sealed and sent to the treasury. Everyone is searched while exiting; TTD is now expanding automation to reduce manual handling.

SHIRDI, MAHARASHTRA

The Shree Sai Baba Sansthan Trust has annual receipts of Rs 850 crore from donations and bank interest. Cash collections are counted twice a week under CCTV surveillance by Trust officials, with a charity commissioner's representative and bank officials present. Staff are frisked at the counting centre and must wear pocketless kurta-pyjamas. Gold and silver donations are valued by an official valuer and converted into coins. The trust has internal and external auditors, and its annual report is placed before the Maharashtra legislature.



ANI

JAGANNATH PURI, ODISHA

The control of all movable and immovable assets is vested with the temple managing committee. For 2024-25, it had an annual budget of Rs 413 crore (along with a dedicated corpus fund of Rs 500 crore from the state). Donations are put into separate funds: 90 per cent of hundi collections go into long-term fixed deposits, 10 per cent and small donations into the temple fund for daily expenses; and donations above Rs 1 lakh are transferred to the temple corpus fund. The Ratna Bhandar jewellery inventory check is done under CCTV surveillance and has so far shown no discrepancies.

DEVASWOM BOARDS, KERALA

Kerala has five Devaswom boards—Guruvayur, Travancore, Malabar, Cochin and Koodalmanikyam—which together manage nearly 3,000 temples. The Travancore Devaswom Board oversees major temples, including Sabarimala, which generated Rs 332 crore in 2025-26. But the alleged Sabarimala gold loot exposed the risks of insider control: the investigation found temple artefacts were moved for gold-plating without proper authorisation, records falsified by marking gold plates as copper-

the mandatory double-lock system. The counting room in the basement of the pilgrim centre was the chief arena for this dark drama. With investigators uncovering blind spots in its camera coverage, it was pretty much an opaque proscenium with no fourth wall. Within its confines, the *hundi*s were opened, the cash manually sorted, stacked into bundles, then counted by machines. Investigators speak of various sleights of hand: like extra notes being stealthily inserted in bundles, to be purloined later. For a while, a temporary police outpost in the complex, too, doubled up as a counting room, but security, by all accounts, was relaxed. No frisking at the exit, no pocketless clothing, no independent witnesses, no fly on the wall. The sentinel could freely turn predatory.

Speaking to INDIA TODAY, a senior police official confirmed weaknesses in surveillance. Nearly 800 CCTV cameras covered the premises, he said, with live feeds from almost all cameras available at the central control room. However, feeds from four or five cameras covering the counting area remained password-protected and accessible only to a handful of individuals. "The day the issue surfaced, we went to examine those feeds and asked for access. Only then were the passwords removed," the officer said. The lacunae are surprising, given that these formed a key part of the warnings issued by an audit and risk management review six years ago.